

Milan Mossé
milan_mosse@berkeley.edu
mmosse19.github.io
(626) 710-2177

Employment

Fall 2026 (expected) **Embedded Ethics Fellow**, Stanford University
The McCoy Family Center for Ethics in Society, in partnership with
the Institute for Human-Centered Artificial Intelligence

Education

2026 (expected) **Ph.D.**, Philosophy, University of California, Berkeley
Committee: Johann Frick (co-chair), R. Jay Wallace (co-chair), Anna Stilz

2024 **M.S.**, Computer Science, Stanford University
Research supervisors: Thomas Icard, Omer Reingold, Li-Yang Tan

2020 **B.A.** Philosophy (Honors), **B.S.** Math, Stanford University
Thesis advisors: Michael Bratman, Barry Maguire

Areas

Specialization: Ethics (Practical Ethics; Normative Ethics; Metaethics) and Political Philosophy

Competence: Action, Language, Logic, Race, Science (esp. Cognitive Science and Causation)

Dissertation: Reasons by Request

Requesters seem to have what is, on reflection, a remarkable power: to create reasons at will. My dissertation explores this central but overlooked dimension of our normative lives. How can requesters give us reasons to do what they want, even when they stand in no relation of authority over us? And what would be lost if we saw requests as devices for communicating the existence of pre-existing reasons, rather than creating new ones? I explain how requests create reasons and how the values served by the power to request constrain its permissible use. In characterizing the valuable relationships sustained by requests, my dissertation develops a view of reciprocity that sheds new light on a wide range of further issues, including the morality of markets, duties of fairness, distributive justice, and our reasons to care about future generations.

Peer-reviewed publications

 [Google Scholar](#)  [PhilPapers](#)

forth. How Requests Create Reasons
Philosophy & Phenomenological Research

- 2026 Stable Voting and the Splitting of Cycles
Association for the Advancement of Artificial Intelligence // Wesley H. Holliday, Milan Mossé, Chase Norman, Eric Pacuit, Cynthia Wang
- 2025 How to Count Sore Throats
Analysis // Léa Bourguignon, Milan Mossé
- 2024 On Probabilistic and Causal Reasoning with Summation Operators
Journal of Logic and Computation // Duligur Ibeling, Thomas Icard, Milan Mossé
- 2024 Social Choice for AI Alignment: Dealing with Diverse Human Feedback
International Conference on Machine Learning // Vincent Conitzer, Rachel Freedman, Jobst Heitzig, Wesley Holliday, Bob Jacobs, Nathan Lambert, Milan Mossé, Eric Pacuit, Stuart Russell, Hailey Schoelkopf, Emanuel Tewolde, William Zwicker
- 2023 Probing the Quantitative-Qualitative Divide in Probabilistic Reasoning
Annals of Pure and Applied Logic // Duligur Ibeling, Thomas Icard, Krzysztof Mierzewski, Milan Mossé
- 2023 Multiplicative Metric Fairness Under Composition
Foundations of Responsible Computing // Milan Mossé
- 2022 Is Causal Reasoning Harder than Probabilistic Reasoning?
Review of Symbolic Logic // Milan Mossé, Duligur Ibeling, Thomas Icard
- 2022 A Generalization of the Satisfiability Coding Lemma and Its Applications
International Conference on Theory and Applications of Satisfiability Testing // Milan Mossé, Harry Sha, Li-Yang Tan ([Best Theory Paper Award](#))
- 2021 Conditional Negative Sampling for Contrastive Learning of Visual Representations
International Conference on Machine Learning // Mike Wu, Milan Mossé, Chengxu Zhuang, Daniel Yamins, Noah Goodman
- 2019 Zero Shot Learning for Code Education: Rubric Sampling with Deep Learning Inference
Association for the Advancement of Artificial Intelligence // Mike Wu, Milan Mossé, Noah Goodman, Chris Piech ([Outstanding Student Paper Award](#))

Revise and resubmit

- ⌚ Why Not Ask?
Ethics

Under review

- ⌚ Modeling Discrimination with Causal Abstraction
 Milan Mossé, Kara Schechtman, Frederick Eberhardt, Thomas Icard
[Nominated for Best Paper, FAccT 2026](#)
- ⌚ Individualist Moral Theory and Its Limits
 Léa Bourguignon, Jonas Harney, Milan Mossé

Awards & fellowships

2024-25	Graduate Fellow, Kavli Center for Ethics, Science, and the Public, UC Berkeley
2025	Dissertation Completion Fellowship, UC Berkeley
2023	Outstanding GSI Award (awarded to fewer than 10% of TAs), UC Berkeley
2020	Cota Robles Fellowship, UC Berkeley
2019	Major Grant, Stanford
2017-19	Mellon Mays Undergraduate Fellow, Stanford
2017	Chappell-Lougee Scholarship, Stanford

Selected presentations

Modeling Discrimination with Causal Abstraction

2026	ACM Conference on Fairness, Accountability, and Transparency (FAccT)
2026	To Be or Not to Be Included in a Causal Model, University of Pittsburgh
2026	Departmental Talk, University of Michigan
2025	Departmental Talk, Emory University*
2024	CEPDISC, Aarhus University
2024	Stanford Logic Seminar*

How Requests Create Reasons

2026	Berkeley-London Conference
2026	Eastern APA Symposium

How Questions Structure Plans (with Seth Yalcin, various titles)

2026	5th Annual Conference of the Philosophy of Language Association, UCLA
2026	Planning Workshop, Stanford University*
2026	Eastern APA Symposium*
2024	Agency and Intentions in Language, Harvey Mudd College

Individualism and Its Limits

2026	Choice Group, London School of Economics*
2025	Workshop on Moral Aggregation, University of Manchester
2025	Rocky Mountain Philosophy Conference, University of Colorado Boulder

Reasoning about Confirmation

2025	Probability Logic Workshop, Carnegie Mellon University
------	--

Why Not Ask? (formerly “The Requesting-Offering Asymmetry”)

2025	Central APA Symposium
2024	Rocky Mountain Ethics Congress, University of Colorado Boulder

How to Count Sore Throats

2023	Choice Group, London School of Economics*
------	---

*invited; all others via application

Graduate coursework

University of California, Berkeley

Fall 2025	Philosophy of Language, with Seth Yalcin*
Spr 2025	Ethics and Time, with Johann Frick*
Fall 2024	Disagreement, with Joshua Cohen & Véronique Munoz-Dardé*
2022-23	Qualifying Exams
	Hume's Sentimentalism, with Olivia Bailey
	Contractualism, with R. Jay Wallace
	Question-Sensitivity, with Seth Yalcin
Spr 2022	Individual, Social, and Ethical Choice, with Wesley Holliday
Spr 2022	Thought, Character, and Action in Aristotle, with Tim Clarke
Fall 2021	Ethical Theories, with R. Jay Wallace
Fall 2021	The Common Ground, with John MacFarlane & Seth Yalcin
Spr 2021	Hume, with Olivia Bailey
Spr 2021	Pragmatism, with Shamik Dasgupta
Fall 2020	Feminist Epistemology, with Andreja Novakovic
Fall 2020	Evolutionary & Developmental Perspectives on Morality, with Jan Engelmann & R. Jay Wallace
Fall 2020	Property, with Joshua Cohen & Desmond Jagmohan
Fall 2020	Proseminar, with John Campbell & Hannah Ginsborg

Stanford University

Spr 2024	Artificial Intelligence: Principles and Techniques, with Nima Anari, Moses Charikar, and Sanmi Koyejo
Spr 2024	The Ethical Analyst, with Dale Nesbitt
Spr 2023	Decision Theory and Planning Agency, with Thomas Icard & Michael Bratman*
Fall 2020	Research Seminar in Complexity Theory, with Li-Yang Tan
Spr 2020	Complexity Theory II, with Li-Yang Tan
Win 2020	Complexity Theory, with Li-Yang Tan
Win 2020	Optimization and Algorithmic Paradigms, with Moses Charikar
Win 2020	Theory of Probability II (Statistics PhD Sequence), with Amir Dembo
Fall 2019	Theory of Probability I (Statistics PhD Sequence), with Andrea Montanari
Fall 2019	Research Seminar on Logic and Formal Philosophy, with Thomas Icard
Spr 2019	Topics in Logic, Information, and Agency, with Johan van Benthem & Thomas Icard
Spr 2019	Topics in Aesthetics, with Kendall Walton
Spr 2019	Topics in Combinatorics, with Jacob Fox
Win 2019	Algebraic Error Correcting Codes, with Mary Wootters
Spr 2018	Planning, Time, and Rationality, with Michael Bratman

*audited; all others for credit

Teaching

University of California, Berkeley

Fall 2025	TA, Philosophy of Science, with Ezra Rubenstein
Fall 2024	TA, Political Philosophy: Equality and Identity, with Véronique Munoz-Dardé

Sum 2024	Co-Instructor, Individual Morality and Social Justice, with Russell McIntosh
Fall 2023	TA, Political Philosophy, with Véronique Munoz-Dardé
Sum 2023	TA, Contemporary Ethical Issues, with Tim Crockett
Fall 2022	TA, Bioethics, with Johann Frick
Sum 2022	TA, Philosophy of Race, Ethnicity, and Citizenship, with Tim Crockett
Spr 2022	TA, Individual Morality and Social Justice, with Johann Frick
Fall 2021	TA, Nature of Mind, with John Campbell

Stanford University

Spr 2024	TA, Incentives in Computer Science, with Aviad Rubenstein
Sum 2020	TA, Design and Analysis of Algorithms, with Karey Shi
Win 2020	TA, Design and Analysis of Algorithms, with Mary Wootters
Spr 2021	Guest Lecturer, Standard C++ Programming Laboratory, with Ali Malik
Win 2018	TA, Programming Abstractions, with Marty Stepp
Fall 2018	TA, Programming Methodology, with Mehran Sahami

Service

Diversity, equity, and inclusion

AY 2021-22, 2024-25	Graduate Representative, Equity Task Force; Focus on Trans Inclusion
AY 2021-22, 2023-24	Co-Organizer, Minorities and Philosophy
Fall 2022	Co-Organizer, COMPASS Workshop
Spr 2021	Un-Naming Proposal Co-Author, Moses Hall Name Review Committee

Other organizing, chairing, and refereeing

Fall 2025	Co-Organizer, MANCEPT Limited Aggregation Workshop
Spr 2022, 2023, 2025	Founder, Co-Organizer, & Mentor, Directed Reading Program
AY 2020-21, 2023-2024	Organizer, Graduate Work-in-Progress Talks
Spr 2023	Grad Organizer, Social Choice for AI Ethics & Safety Workshop
AY 2022-23	Grad Organizer, Department Colloquia
Spr 2021/2023, AY 2023-24	Organizer, Faculty Work-in-Progress Talks
Spr 2022	Organizer, Latin American Philosophy Reading Group
AY 2021-22	Organizer, Feminism and Masculinity Reading Group
Chair (selected)	Central APA (2025); Arizona Workshop in Normative Ethics (2025; invitation by submitted abstract); Rocky Mountain Ethics Congress (2024)

Referee

Computational Complexity Conference (CCC); Conference on Neural Information Processing Systems (NeurIPS; ×5); International Conference on Machine Learning (ICML; ×5); International Colloquium on Automata, Languages and Programming (ICALP); International Symposium on Algorithms and Computation (ISAAC); Journal of Logic and Computation; Journal of Moral Philosophy (×5); Logic Journal of the IGPL (×3); Noûs; Philosophical Studies (×2); Philosophy; Philosophy & Technology; Review of Symbolic Logic; Utilitas

Skills

Languages: Spanish (professional proficiency) and German (reading)

Coding: C, C++, Python

References

Thomas F. Icard

C. I. Lewis Professor of Philosophy and (by courtesy) Professor of Computer Science

Stanford University

icard@stanford.edu

Johann Frick

Associate Professor of Philosophy

University of California, Berkeley

jfrick@berkeley.edu

Véronique Munoz-Dardé (teaching reference)

Professor of Philosophy

University College London

Mills Adjunct Professor of Philosophy

University of California, Berkeley

munoz_darde@berkeley.edu

R. Jay Wallace

William and Trudy Ausfahl Chair in Philosophy

University of California, Berkeley

rjw@berkeley.edu

Seth Yalcin

Professor of Philosophy

University of California, Berkeley

yalcin@berkeley.edu

Reasons by Request

Dissertation Summary

You are not required to stop and aid every stranger you encounter. Seeing a lost tourist, you might cite your discretion to defer assistance for another occasion, thinking to yourself, “I will help the next time I see someone in their shoes.” But this thought rings hollow when the lost stranger *requests* your guidance. Your normative situation has changed, and you must now give a reason for not helping in this particular case, or else provide assistance. Requesters have what is, on reflection, a remarkable power: to create reasons at will. The central puzzle of requests is to explain how this is possible. How can requesters give us reasons to do what they want, even when they stand in no relation of authority over us? And what would be lost if we saw requests as communicating the existence of pre-existing reasons, rather than creating new ones?

My dissertation begins by answering this question. At the center of my account is the idea that we have reasons to grant requests because doing so improves our compliance with *imperfect duties*—duties that grant us significant discretion to decide how to comply. Any time you can help a stranger, you can also think to yourself that you will help next time, and we are correspondingly liable to fall short of our imperfect duties to help others. As a result, it is valuable for you to accept that the lost stranger’s request prevents you from just citing your generic interest in discretion, by providing a reason for compliance in this particular case. Just as religious traditions improve compliance with imperfect duties to give to charities by establishing regular times and recipients for donations, requests improve compliance with imperfect duties more generally.

My account does not appeal to *pre-existing, intimate* relationships between the requester and the requestee. How do the values served by the power to request constrain its permissible use, given that we wield this power at will over perfect strangers? What do we owe to the recipients of our requests? I approach these questions by way of an asymmetry between requests and offers: it is often not okay to request an act, but perfectly fine to accept an offer for it. What might explain this? After all, the request and offer result in the same duty upon their acceptance, and they concern the same act. My second chapter argues that some requests are wrongful *precisely because they create reasons*. Creating a reason often generates a double-bind for the requestee: if they act as requested, they pay the practical cost of doing so; if they do not, they pay a moral cost, in the form of a reason for regret. While this double-bind does not always make requests wrongful, I show how it can be intrusive, manipulative, and coercive. Offers do not create the same double-bind, I argue, because offers do not as such create reasons.

Even if requests do not generally invoke antecedent relationships, they create reasons which lead us to develop them. Prior work models these relationships in terms of *material* reciprocity: the mutual exchange of benefits. I argue that requests are not just efficient vehicles for exchanging benefits, but can function to develop intrinsically valuable relationships. They thereby sustain *relational* reciprocity, which is realized when we share responsibility for deepening the value of a relationship. My third chapter defends the distinction between material and relational reciprocity and argues that it sheds new light on a wide range of further issues, including the morality of markets, duties of fairness, distributive justice, and our reasons to care about future generations.